

Know the term. Explain the rule.

127 concise definitions from the combined source-backed workbook, with original Google section links.

127

DEFINITIONS

95

SUPPLIED DOCUMENTS

Reviewed 6 October 2026 · Combined fundamentals, crawling, ranking and appearance edition

301 redirect

An HTTP redirect indicating a permanent move and strongly signaling the destination as canonical.

[Redirects and Google Search](#) · [Permanent server-side redirects](#)

302 redirect

An HTTP redirect indicating a temporary move; the original URL generally remains the preferred canonical.

[Redirects and Google Search](#) · [Permanent server-side redirects](#)

404 response

An HTTP response indicating that the requested page is missing; a helpful custom error page should still return this status.

[Maintaining your website's SEO](#) · [Migrating a single URL](#)

429 response

An HTTP response indicating too many requests; it can be used for urgent crawler throttling, with site-wide crawl-rate consequences.

[Reduce the Google crawl rate](#) · [Urgently reduce crawler traffic \(for emergencies\)](#)

503 response

An HTTP response indicating temporary service unavailability; short maintenance use differs from prolonged unavailability.

[Temporarily pause or disable a website](#) · [Not recommended: Disable the whole website](#)

75th-percentile assessment

Assessing Web Vitals at the value met by 75% of page visits, separately for mobile and desktop.

[Web Vitals](#) · [Core Web Vitals](#)

A/B testing

Comparing site variations; when separate URLs are used, Google recommends appropriate canonicals and temporary redirects.

[Minimize A/B testing impact in Google Search](#) · [Use rel="canonical" links](#)

AEO

Answer engine optimization, a term used for improving AI-search visibility; Google treats optimizing its generative search experience as SEO.

[Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?](#)

Aggregator unit

A regional Search presentation linking to aggregator inventory or category pages, with participation requirements beyond ordinary markup.

[Aggregator unit in Google Search](#) · [How the aggregator unit works](#)

AI agent

An autonomous system that performs tasks for people, potentially interacting with pages through rendered views, the DOM or accessibility information.

[Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Explore agentic experiences](#)

AI Overviews and AI Mode

Google Search generative AI experiences grounded in core Search systems; ordinary SEO foundations remain relevant.

[Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?](#)

Allow

A robots.txt instruction permitting crawling of a matching path; the most specific applicable path rule wins.

[How Google interprets the robots.txt specification](#) · [Order of precedence for rules](#)

Alt text

Descriptive image text; for an image used as a link, Google uses its alt attribute as anchor text.

[Link best practices for Google](#) · [Anchor text placement](#)

Anchor text

The visible text of a link, helping users and Google understand the linked page.

[Link best practices for Google](#) · [Write good anchor text](#)

BERT

A system Google uses to understand how word combinations express different meanings and intent.

[A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [BERT](#)

Breadcrumb

A hierarchical indication of a page's position within a site; appropriate structured data can help Google represent that hierarchy.

[Establish your business details with Google](#) · [Update your site's Google knowledge panel](#)

Canonicalization

Selecting a representative URL from duplicate or very similar pages to reduce redundant results.

[What is canonicalization](#) · [What is canonicalization](#)

CLS

Cumulative Layout Shift measures visual stability; a good value is at most 0.1 at the 75th percentile.

[Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results](#) · [Core Web Vitals metrics](#)

Content fingerprinting

Putting a version or content hash in a resource filename so changed JavaScript or CSS is fetched rather than served from a stale cache.

[Understand the JavaScript SEO basics](#) · [Use long-lived caching](#)

Core update

A broad change to Search's systems; a visibility decline after one does not itself demonstrate a site-specific penalty.

[Google Search's core updates and your website](#) · [How core updates work](#)

Core Web Vitals

User-experience metrics for loading, responsiveness and visual stability: LCP, INP and CLS.

[Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results](#) · [Core Web Vitals metrics](#)

Crawl budget

The number of URLs Google's crawlers can and want to crawl, governed by crawl capacity and crawl demand.

[Optimize your crawl budget](#) · [General theory of crawling](#)

Crawl capacity limit

The crawling capacity Google permits to avoid overloading a site; server responsiveness affects it.

[Optimize your crawl budget](#) · [Crawl capacity limit](#)

Crawl demand

Google's desire to crawl URLs, influenced by factors such as inventory and how stale content may be.

[Optimize your crawl budget](#) · [Crawl demand](#)

Crawling

Fetching page content with an automated crawler. A discovered URL is not guaranteed to be crawled.

[In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Introducing the three stages of Google Search](#)

Crypto redirect

A move communicated through explanatory text and a link; Google advises against relying on it when other redirect methods are available.

[Redirects and Google Search](#) · [Overview of redirect types](#)

data-nosnippet

An HTML attribute excluding a marked text region from snippets; its presence applies regardless of a false-looking value.

[Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications](#) · [Using the data-nosnippet HTML attribute](#)

Disallow

A robots.txt instruction restricting crawling of matching paths. A URL may still be indexed from other signals.

[Introduction to robots.txt](#) · [What is a robots.txt file used for?](#)

Discover

A feed showing content relevant to users' interests; eligibility does not require special markup or only newly published articles.

[Discover and your website](#) · [How content appears in Discover](#)

DOM text

Text accessible in the document object model; important copy should not exist only in CSS-generated content or a canvas.

[Get started with Search: a developer's guide](#) · [Don't forget about the words on the page](#)

Duplicate content

The same or similar content available through multiple URLs; ordinary duplication is not itself a manual-action penalty.

[Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#) · [Reduce duplicate content](#)

Dynamic rendering

Routing crawlers to rendered HTML while serving ordinary users normally; a workaround that Google does not recommend as a long-term default.

[Dynamic rendering as a workaround](#) · [Understand how dynamic rendering works](#)

E-E-A-T

Experience, expertise, authoritativeness and trustworthiness; trust is central, and E-E-A-T is not itself one specific ranking factor.

[Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines](#)

Ecosystem carousel

A regional carousel connecting users with providers in a relevant ecosystem, without requiring a new feed or markup type.

[Ecosystem carousel in Google Search](#) · [Ecosystem carousel in Google Search](#)

Eligibility versus display

Meeting technical, content and policy requirements makes a feature possible; it does not guarantee that Google shows it.

[General structured data guidelines](#) · [General structured data guidelines](#)

Enriched search result

A richer, interactive result experience beyond a basic rich result, subject to additional requirements.

[Enriched search results](#) · [Enriched search results](#)

Favicon

A site icon that may appear beside a result; it must be square and meet Google's crawlability and size guidance.

[Define a favicon to show in search results](#) · [Guidelines](#)

Featured snippet

An automatically selected extract prominently answering a query; publishers cannot mark a page as the featured snippet.

[Featured snippets and your website](#) · [How can I mark my page as a featured snippet?](#)

Flexible sampling

Approaches to offering some paywalled content access, including metering and lead-in, rather than requiring unlimited free access.

[Flexible Sampling general guidance](#) · [Flexible Sampling general guidance](#)

GEO

Generative engine optimization, another term for AI-search visibility work; it does not replace Google's established SEO principles.

[Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?](#)

Google Business Profile

A Google business-information product that can help local services and products be visible in Search and relevant AI responses.

[Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Optimize your local business and ecommerce details](#)

Google request verification

Confirming genuine Google traffic with reverse and forward DNS checks, or matching published Google IP ranges at scale.

[Verify requests from Google crawlers and fetchers](#) · [Use command line tools](#)

Google Search Console

Google's first-party tool for information and data about a site's presence in Google Search.

[Google Search's guidance on using third-party SEO tools, services, and advice](#) · [Think critically about using third-party SEO tools and services](#)

Google-selected canonical

The representative URL Google actually chooses; inspect it when it differs from the publisher's preference.

[Fix canonicalization issues](#) · [Fix canonicalization issues](#)

Googlebot

Google's crawler that fetches pages; its crawl decisions and rate are algorithmic.

[In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Crawling](#)

Hosting migration

Changing hosting infrastructure while retaining existing URLs; verify the new environment and DNS transition.

[Changing your hosting](#) · [Changing your hosting](#)

hreflang

An annotation identifying alternative language or regional versions of a page.

[Maintaining your website's SEO](#) · [Internationalized or multi-lingual sites](#)

Image sitemap

Image information added to a sitemap, either alongside page URLs or in a separate sitemap.

[Image sitemaps](#) · [Image sitemaps](#)

indexifembedded

With noindex, permits indexing when content is embedded through an iframe or similar tag; alone it has no effect.

[Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet, and X-Robots-Tag specifications](#) · [Valid indexing and serving rules](#)

Indexing

Analyzing a page and its text, images, video and metadata, and potentially storing information in Google's index.

[In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Indexing](#)

INP

Interaction to Next Paint measures responsiveness; a good value is at most 200 milliseconds at the 75th percentile.

[Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results](#) · [Core Web Vitals metrics](#)

Intrusive interstitial

An overlay or intermediate experience that obstructs access to expected main content; legal requirements have different considerations.

[Avoid intrusive interstitials and dialogs](#) · [Use banners instead of interstitials](#)

IPTC DigitalSourceType

Image provenance metadata; Merchant Center requires TrainedAlgorithmicMedia metadata for AI-generated images.

[Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Give users context](#)

Job sites feature

A regional job-site aggregator presentation and refinement chip; it is distinct from the JobPosting structured-data feature.

[Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip](#) · [Job sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip](#)

JSON-LD

A supported structured-data format placing linked data in a JSON script block; Google generally recommends it.

[Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search](#) · [Get started with structured data](#)

lastmod

A sitemap timestamp for the last significant update; it must reflect actual changes rather than routine regeneration.

[Build and submit a sitemap](#) · [Additional notes about XML sitemaps](#)

Lazy loading

Deferring resources or content until needed; make loading possible when visible in the viewport without user interaction.

[Fix lazy-loaded content](#) · [Load content when it's visible in the viewport](#)

LCP

Largest Contentful Paint measures loading performance; a good value is at most 2.5 seconds at the 75th percentile.

[Understanding Core Web Vitals and Google search results](#) · [Core Web Vitals metrics](#)

Lead-in

Showing part of an article before requiring payment or subscription to access the remainder.

[Flexible Sampling general guidance](#) · [Flexible Sampling general guidance](#)

llms.txt

A machine-readable file some services may use; Google Search says it ignores such files for visibility and ranking.

[Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Mythbusting generative AI search: what you don't need to do](#)

Main content

Any part of a page directly helping it fulfill its purpose, including text, media, tools, relevant user contributions and tabbed information.

[Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Main content](#)

max-image-preview

A directive controlling allowed image-preview size: none, standard or large.

[Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications](#) · [Valid indexing and serving rules](#)

max-snippet

A directive setting the maximum text-snippet length in characters; -1 permits no specified limit and 0 prevents text snippets.

[Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications](#) · [Valid indexing and serving rules](#)

max-video-preview

A directive setting the video-preview length in seconds; -1 permits no specified limit and 0 allows a static image.

[Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications](#) · [Valid indexing and serving rules](#)

Merchant Center

A Google product for supplying product information, including feeds, that can help products appear in Search and AI responses.

[Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Optimize your local business and ecommerce details](#)

Meta description

A page-level summary that Google may use for a snippet; page content and the user's query can produce a different snippet.

[Control your snippets in search results](#) · [How snippets are created](#)

Metering

Offering a limited number of free articles before requiring a subscription.

[Flexible Sampling general guidance](#) · [Flexible Sampling general guidance](#)

Microdata

A supported structured-data format using HTML attributes to associate properties with visible content.

[Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search](#) · [Get started with structured data](#)

Mobile-first indexing

Using the mobile version's content, fetched by the smartphone crawler, for indexing and ranking.

[Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices](#) · [Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices](#)

mRSS

A supported Media RSS alternative for supplying video information to Google.

[Video sitemaps and alternatives](#) · [Sitemap alternative: mRSS](#)

Neural matching

An AI system that understands representations of concepts in queries and pages and matches them.

[A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [BERT](#)

News sitemap

A sitemap extension for news articles; keep news entries limited to articles published in the previous two days.

[News sitemaps](#) · [News sitemap best practices](#)

noimageindex

A page-level directive preventing indexing of images from that page; an image may still be indexed from another page.

[Remove images hosted on your site from search results](#) · [Remove images with the noindex X-Robots-Tag HTTP header](#)

noindex

A directive preventing indexing after Google can crawl and process it; it does not make the content private.

[Block Search indexing with noindex](#) · [Implementing noindex](#)

Non-commodity content

Distinctive information or experienced analysis that adds value beyond common knowledge and recycled summaries.

[Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Create valuable, non-commodity content for your audience](#)

nosnippet

A directive preventing text snippets and video previews in Search; it differs from excluding the page from indexing.

[Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet , and X-Robots-Tag specifications](#) · [Valid indexing and serving rules](#)

Package tracking feature

An early-adopter carrier integration for shipment status; the current guide says it is not accepting new partners.

[Package tracking Early Adopters Program](#) · [Package tracking Early Adopters Program](#)

PageRank

A link-analysis system that remains part of Google's ranking systems; links are not the whole ranking process.

[Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#) · [Things we believe you shouldn't focus on](#)

People-first content

Content created primarily to help an intended human audience rather than manipulate search rankings.

[Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Focus on people-first content](#)

Places sites feature

A regional presentation and refinement option for sites supplying place information; availability is feature-specific.

[Places sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip](#) · [Places sites: aggregator carousel and refinement chip](#)

Preferred source

A source a user selects to appear more often for relevant stories in Top Stories; it does not guarantee exclusive results.

[Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search](#) · [Help your readers find your site through preferred sources in Google Search](#)

Query fan-out

Concurrent related queries generated to gather additional information for an original user query.

[Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?](#)

RAG

Retrieval-augmented generation: grounding an AI response in relevant, current pages retrieved through core Search systems.

[Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search](#) · [Is SEO still relevant for generative AI search?](#)

RankBrain

An AI system that relates words to concepts, helping find relevant content even without the exact query wording.

[A guide to Google Search ranking systems](#) · [BERT](#)

RDFa

A supported structured-data format using HTML attributes to express linked-data properties.

[Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search](#) · [Get started with structured data](#)

Redirect chain

A sequence of redirects before the final destination; avoid unnecessary hops during migrations.

[How to move a site](#) · [Plan your redirect strategy](#)

rel=canonical

A declaration of the publisher's preferred representative URL; it is a strong signal rather than an absolute command.

[How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods](#) · [How to specify a canonical URL with rel="canonical" and other methods](#)

rel=nofollow

A qualification for a link relationship the publisher does not endorse; it does not guarantee the target is never crawled or indexed.

[Qualify your outbound links to Google](#) · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#)

rel=sponsored

A link qualification for advertising, sponsorship or other paid placements.

[Qualify your outbound links to Google](#) · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#)

rel=ugc

A link qualification for user-generated contributions such as forum posts and comments.

[Qualify your outbound links to Google](#) · [Qualify your outbound links to Google](#)

Rendering

Processing a page, including supported JavaScript, to obtain the content a browser would display.

[In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Crawling](#)

Responsive design

A configuration serving the same URL and HTML while adapting its display for devices; Google recommends it for maintainability.

[Mobile site and mobile-first indexing best practices](#) · [Create a mobile-friendly site](#)

Reviews system

A system rewarding substantial analysis and original review research; it differs from evaluating customer comments on product pages.

[Google Search's reviews system and your website](#) · [How the reviews system works](#)

Rich result

A Search result with additional presentation features made possible by supported content and compliant markup; display is not guaranteed.

[Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search](#) · [How structured data works in Google Search](#)

Robots wildcard

The * character matches any character sequence in a robots path; \$ marks the end of a URL.

[How Google interprets the robots.txt specification](#) · [URL matching based on path values](#)

robots.txt

A host-specific file that tells supported crawlers which resources they may request; it is not a privacy mechanism.

[Introduction to robots.txt](#) · [Introduction to robots.txt](#)

Scaled content abuse

Producing many pages without added user value, particularly to manipulate ranking; using AI does not excuse this behavior.

[Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#)

Search profile

A Google profile users can follow to discover content from creators or organizations, including through Discover.

[Add a Search profile badge to your website](#) · [How Search profiles work on Google](#)

Search quality raters

People who evaluate whether Search systems provide good results; their individual ratings do not directly set rankings.

[Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines](#)

SEO

Helping search engines understand content and helping people find a site and decide whether to visit it.

[Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#) · [Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#)

Server-side rendering

Producing page HTML on the server; it can improve access to content rather than relying entirely on client-side JavaScript.

[Understand the JavaScript SEO basics](#) · [How Google processes JavaScript](#)

Serving search results

Selecting relevant results from the index in response to a query, considering quality and context.

[In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Serving search results](#)

Single-page application

An application using one HTML page; each independently meaningful screen or content item still needs a discoverable URL.

[Get started with Search: a developer's guide](#) · [Check your links](#)

Site name

The name identifying a site in Search, distinct from a page-specific title link.

[Provide a site name to Google Search](#) · [Provide a site name to Google Search](#)

Sitelinks

Additional links under a result that Google generates automatically from a site's structure and other signals.

[Sitelinks](#) · [Sitelinks best practices](#)

Sitemap

A file giving information about pages, videos and other files, and their relationships, to help discovery and crawling.

[Learn about sitemaps](#) · [Learn about sitemaps](#)

Sitemap index

A file listing multiple sitemap files so large URL inventories can be split and submitted together.

[Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file](#) · [Manage your sitemaps with a sitemap index file](#)

Snippet

A Search result's descriptive text, generated mainly from page content and sometimes from its meta description.

[Control your snippets in search results](#) · [How snippets are created](#)

Soft 404

A URL whose content indicates an error or missing page without the appropriate missing-page HTTP response.

[Troubleshoot Google Search crawling errors](#) · [soft 404 errors](#)

Spam update

A notable improvement to automated spam detection, distinct from the systems' ongoing detection work.

[Google Search spam updates and your site](#) · [Google Search spam updates and your site](#)

Structured data

Standardized markup supplying explicit information about a page and classifying its content for supported Search features.

[Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search](#) · [How structured data works in Google Search](#)

Structured-data carousel beta

A region-limited host carousel with summary and standalone detail pages; it is different from an aggregator unit.

[Structured data carousels \(beta\)](#) · [Structured data carousels \(beta\)](#)

structured_description

The Merchant Center attribute for an AI-generated description, with content and digital_source_type sub-attributes.

[Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Give users context](#)

structured_title

The Merchant Center attribute for an AI-generated title, with content and digital_source_type sub-attributes.

[Google Search's guidance on using generative AI content on your website](#) · [Give users context](#)

Supplier unit

A regional presentation of suppliers' own listings, distinct from aggregator links; consult its specific eligibility guide.

[Supplier unit in Google Search](#) · [How the supplier unit works](#)

Title link

The clickable headline of a Search result; Google can generate it from several sources, beyond the HTML title.

[Influencing your title links in search results](#) · [How title links in Google Search are created](#)

Top Places List

A feature showing eligible publisher lists of places; follow the guide's content and publisher requirements.

[Top Places List](#) · [Top Places List](#)

Translated result

A result offering a Google-translated page experience when relevant; the publisher does not need to opt in.

[Translated results in Google Search](#) · [Opting in or out of translated results](#)

URL discovery

Finding that a URL exists, for example through links from known pages or a sitemap; discovery precedes a possible crawl.

[In-depth guide to how Google Search works](#) · [Crawling](#)

URL Inspection

A Search Console tool for investigating what Google sees and a URL's crawling, indexing and canonical status.

[Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\) Starter Guide](#) · [Check if Google can see your page the same way a user does](#)

URL migration

Moving content to different URLs, requiring destination preparation, URL mapping, redirects and monitoring.

[How to move a site](#) · [Overview](#)

Video sitemap

A sitemap extension describing videos, including their thumbnail, title, description and content or player location.

[Video sitemaps and alternatives](#) · [mRSS reference](#)

Watch page

A page whose main purpose is watching a single video; it differs from a page where video is incidental.

[Video SEO best practices](#) · [Create a dedicated watch page for each video](#)

Web Story

A visual, tap-through content format; Google's implementation requires valid AMP and specified metadata.

[Enable Web Stories on Google](#) · [Enable Web Stories on Google](#)

X-Robots-Tag

An HTTP response header carrying indexing or preview directives, including for non-HTML resources such as PDFs.

[Robots meta tag, data-nosnippet, and X-Robots-Tag specifications](#) · [Using the robots meta tag](#)

XML sitemap

A sitemap format that can include supported extensions for images, video, news and language alternatives.

[Build and submit a sitemap](#) · [Build and submit a sitemap](#)

YMYL

Your Money or Your Life topics that can significantly affect health, financial stability, safety or societal well-being.

[Creating helpful, reliable, people-first content](#) · [Get to know E-E-A-T and the quality rater guidelines](#)

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